

Poor Man's Floppy

HIGH SPEED CASSETTE SYSTEM



Now the widely acclaimed
JPC Cassette System is available
for your TRS-80* computer.
The price is only \$90.00

TC-8 Cassette System
JPC Products
Albuquerque, NM
Kit: \$90
Assembled: \$120

by Carl A. Kollar

I guess I don't have to tell any TRS-80 owners how frustrating the cassette system that comes with the computer can be. Even with the factory mod that's available, the annoyance of loading and checking programs becomes just barely tolerable.

If you're like me, after you've just plunked down a chunk of money for a Level II 16K machine, "you ain't got nuttin left" for even one disk drive at 500 bucks apiece. So you suffer.

A reasonable alternative is the Exatron Stringy Floppy (ESF). This will cost you about 250 bucks and totally eliminates your loading and saving problems, automatically and fast. I've had one of these for about six months and love it!

But, if the price is still too steep, have I got a device for you!

The Device

The February 1980 issue of *Microcomputing* had an ad that intrigued the hell out of me. It was a high-speed cassette system by JPC Products acclaimed as a "poor man's floppy." It made all sorts of seemingly ridiculous claims such as "loads five times faster," "stores 50,000 bytes on a 10-minute cassette," "less than one bad load in a million bytes with the volume control anywhere between one and eight."

All this for a measly [90] bucks? How could this be? A call to Albuquerque answered a few questions: Yes, it had its own power supply, and, it stored programs five times faster because it utilized higher density data. The computer outputs the information at a higher rate out of the rear keyboard connector.

The ad had even claimed anyone could build it even if you have never soldered before. JPC would make it work, if you couldn't—for free. I was sold. I placed my order, and it arrived about two months later (parts shortage).

I work in electronics, so I found the unit exceptionally easy to build. It took about an hour. The manual is superb. (That's better than great.) It was clear, concise and exact with no

ambiguities. Important parts placements are stressed (polarity markings on electrolytics, bands on diodes, etc.).

JPC was right! With these instructions, you couldn't go wrong. The board quality is excellent. It is double-sided and parts locations are clearly marked on the component side of the board. There are no jumper wires to install. JPC utilizes PC traces and plated-through holes for connections to traces on the other side of the board.

Also, there are absolutely no adjustments or settings to bother with.

The documentation is a sheaf of 8 1/2 x 11 papers stapled together. It is written in the nicest format I've seen in a while. Each command and/or subjects is covered on its own sheet in large type. All explanations are in easy to read English—not computerese.

Commands and Features

SAVE"filename": Saves your BASIC program on cassette.

LOAD: Reads the next BASIC program from the cassette.

LOAD"filename": Searches for and loads the specified file from cassette.

LOAD? and LOAD?"filename": Reads file from cassette, and compares contents to memory.

LOADN: Prints a list of all the programs on a cassette, until interrupted by the "break" key.

LOADN"filename": Same as above except the tape will stop at the end of the program named.

KILL: Removes the file manager program from memory so that the extra memory can be used by large programs.

RSET: Allows the operator to rewind and position the tape on tape recorders that have these functions tied to the motor control jack.

RUN"filename": TC-8 searches for a specified program and runs it immediately.

PUT"filename": Same as SAVE "filename", except it is for use with system tapes.

GET: Same as LOAD, except it is for use with system tapes.

GET"filename": Same as LOAD "filename", except it is for use with system tapes.

GET? and GET?"filename": Same as LOAD? and LOAD?"filename", except it is for use with system tapes.

GETN and GETN"filename": Same as

LOADN and LOADN"filename", except it is for use with system tapes.

OPEN: Required before cassette input or output of a data file can be attempted.

CLOSE: Required to end a cassette data file.

PRINT#: Allows numerical or string data to be output to a cassette file.

INPUT#: Allows numerical or string data to be input from a cassette file.

I haven't counted them, so I don't know about the "one load in a million bytes" claim, but my son, Anthony (age 11), loaded about 30 of his programs from his Radio Shack format tape to a new TC-8 format tape. He's run them all and found no bad loads.

Unlike the standard tape system, you can position your tape anywhere before the program you want and not have to look for a blank spot between programs. The TC-8 patiently waits for the program you want and then starts loading without getting confused by the portion of the previous program you just fed it.

Try that on your regular cassette system; you'll wear out the reset button. ■

ORDER NOW

To order your TC-8 kit, send your check or money order for \$90.00 plus \$3.50 postage and handling to JPC PRODUCTS CO., 12021 Paisano Ct., Albuquerque, NM 87112 (New Mexico residents add 4% sales tax). Credit card orders accepted by phone or mail. Personal checks will delay shipment. We will otherwise immediately ship you the TC-8 kit, the cabinet, the ribbon cable, the power adapter, an instruction manual, and a cassette containing the software.



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